

HASHKAMA



פרשת עקב

י' אב תשפ"ו

JULY 31, 2026

VOL 5786 ISSUE 44

WEEKLY

By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-אמיין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

In Parshas Eikev, Moshe Rabbeinu reminds Klal Yisrael of a wardrobe miracle: "Simlascha lo valsa me'alecha v'raglacha lo vatzeika zeh arba'im shanah" (Devarim 8:4). Rashi (Devarim 8:4) explains that the anan cleaned and ironed their garments continuously, while Shir Hashirim Rabbah (4:11) adds that the clothing actually grew alongside each growing child. For any Litvish mishpachah paying dry cleaning before Yom Tov, this is the ultimate gashmiyus dream: one black suit that grows from bar mitzvah through kolel, never gets shiny at the elbows or needs the cleaners. But Moshe Rabbeinu highlights another physiological miracle: "V'raglacha lo vatzeika." Why mention that their feet never swelled? Ibn Ezra (Devarim 8:4) notes that regular walkers suffer swollen feet, yet in the midbar, despite trekking through rough terrain without insoles, no one needed a podiatrist. Hakadosh Baruch Hu provided total physical suspension of natural wear and tear. Why did Hakadosh Baruch Hu perform such an elaborate tailoring miracle? The Sforno (Devarim 8:4) teaches that removing the mundane distractions of shopping and laundry allowed Klal Yisrael to focus entirely on limud HaTorah. When your wardrobe is managed directly by shamayim, you have no excuses left to miss seder. Everything external was supernaturally sustained without human effort.

How does a wardrobe that never wears out connect to our internal ruchniyus? Later in Parshas Eikev, Moshe Rabbeinu poses a classic klotz kashya: "Atah Yisrael mah Hashem Elokecha sho'el me'imach ki im l'yirah" (Devarim 10:12). The Gemara in Berachos (33b) asks: "Atu yiras shamayim milsa zutrassa hi?" Why would anyone assume that yiras shamayim is a minor expectation? For most of us, obtaining yiras shamayim feels significantly harder than finding parking near shul on Sunday morning. The Gemara answers: "In, l'gabey Moshe milsa zutrassa hi" (Berachos 33b). For Moshe Rabbeinu, it was small. But why should Moshe Rabbeinu's lofty perspective help ordinary yidden? The Mesillas Yesharim (Perek 24) explains that yiras shamayim depends on recognizing that one stands constantly before Hakadosh Baruch Hu. This is the profound bridge between our two pesukim: Moshe Rabbeinu looked at an olam whose pants never ripped and whose shoes never pinched (Devarim 8:4). When Hakadosh Baruch Hu personally launders your suit and cushions your feet every second of forty years, yiras shamayim really is a milsa zutrassa! If shamayim handles all your gashmiyus, then offering yiras shamayim in return is the absolute bare minimum! The physical miracles of the midbar stripped away the illusion of independence, leaving Klal Yisrael with only one genuine job: yiras shamayim.

Practical Takeaway: In our modern olam, we do not have an anan to dry-clean our suits or shoes that miraculously expand, so we must still endure shoe stores and dry cleaners. However, the Chovos Halevavos (Shaar Habitachon, Perek 3) reminds us that our livelihoods and basic needs remain entirely in the hands of Hakadosh Baruch Hu. Our practical takeaway for this week is to stop treating physical errands and wardrobe malfunctions as crises, and start viewing them as background noise. The next time your shoe wears out or your coat needs replacing before Yom Tov, do not lose your yishuv hadaas. Remember that Hakadosh Baruch Hu is still managing your gashmiyus behind the scenes, even via a human shaliach. Focus your energy where it actually matters: generating genuine yiras shamayim and showing up on time for davenen.

News & Simchos!

This week's regular Kiddush features pastries, Kokosh cake, and a mercifully short shiur. Endure a few minutes of rigorous Torah analysis to officially justify your massive carbohydrate intake.

All Previous Newsletters are available to download at:
archive.bm715.vip

Deductible Zechusim!

Want to sponsor a Shabbus Mevarchim Kiddush or למאור נר?

Olam Haba dividends are pending, but our kugel's superiority is halachically indisputable.

Contact Tzvi Zev Rubin:

845-252-1260



Drasha Duty!

Convinced your Chakira can outcompete the pastries for attention?

To deliver the Short Shiur during Kiddush,

Please Contact Rabbi Genack:

646-413-5551



Sponsorship

נר למאור חודש אב
Sponsored by
Mr Landerer



Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:44/7:56 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

מנחה - קבלת שבת pm

8:14 pm שקיעה

4:14/4:40 am (16.1/72) עלות השחר

5:52 am נץ החמה

7:00 am (14 Sergio) שחרית

8:51/9:27 am ס"ז קריאת שמע

10:14/10:39 am ס"ז תפילה

1:03 pm חצות היום

1:38 pm מנחה גדולה (גר"א)

1:45 pm (14 Sergio) מנחה

5:13 pm מנחה קטנה (גר"א)

6:43 pm פלג המנחה (גר"א)

8:13 pm שקיעה

8:59/9:03 pm (8.5/50) צה"כ ר' משה

9:05 pm (52) מעריב

9:13/9:25 pm (60/72) צה"כ



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:37/7:47 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

8:05 pm שקיעה

7:00 am (14 Sergio) שחרית

8:04 pm שקיעה

8:56 pm (52) מעריב

Parshah-ly Punny!

Riddle: Why did Moshe Rabbeinu remind Klal Yisrael that despite forty years of trekking through the rocky midbar, their shoes miraculously never wore out?

Answer: He wanted to reassure the entire kehila that following Hakadosh Baruch Hu is the only guaranteed way to save their souls.

Donations & Payments

Check: Write Out to *Bais Midrash 715*

Credit Card: Visit the link: cc.bm715.vip

Cash: Hand to Tzvi Zev or Adam Edelstein

Zelle: Send to *hashkama* or 845-252-1260

Gift Card/Bitcoin: Do we look like Indian Scammers to you?

משל ונמשל ב-Al תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: Let us picture a familiar scene: a lavish chasunah hosted by a legendary gvir in a sprawling banquet hall. An ambitious yungerman walks into the smorgasbord room, where the carving stations and buffet tables are surrounded by a formidable crowd. While ordinary guests stand meekly in line, this yungerman executes a masterclass in ballroom navigation. With the tactical precision of a seasoned rosh yeshivah dissecting a complex Tosafos, he calculates the exact walking trajectory of the waiters, utilizes strategic elbow-work without spilling a drop of seltzer, and assembles a towering plate of cured meats, sushi, and tiny gourmet appetizers. Later, sitting at his table, a fellow baal habayis marvels at his culinary bounty and asks how he managed to secure such an elite plate while everyone else was stuck behind the noodle kugel. Our hero puffs out his chest and launches into a lengthy shmuess about his personal zerizus, his analytical foresight, his superior athletic reflexes, and his brilliant positioning instincts. He speaks with such immense pride about his plate-stacking genius that he completely overlooks one minor detail: he did not purchase the beef, he did not hire the caterer, he did not rent the ballroom, and he was only invited because his second cousin is the mechutan. His entire success consisted of holding an empty plate while someone else provided the entire simchah for the tzibbur.

Nimshal: In Parshas Eikev, Moshe Rabbeinu warns Klal Yisrael against this exact spiritual hazard when achieving material prosperity: "V'amarta b'levavecha kochi v'otzem yadi asah li es hachayil hazeh" (Devarim 8:17). When a baal habayis closes an impressive real estate transaction, or when a yungerman lands a prestigious shtetl in a competitive yeshivah, the yetzer hara immediately tempts us to sound just like the boastful guest at the smorgasbord. We congratulate our own sharp sevara, our relentless networking, and our tireless business acumen. Yet Moshe Rabbeinu immediately punctures this delusion in the very next pasuk: "V'zacharta es Hashem Elokecha ki hu hanosen lecha koach la'asos chayil" (Devarim 8:18). Targum Onkelos (Devarim 8:18) explains that Hakadosh Baruch Hu grants us the intellectual capacity and advice to acquire wealth, while Rashi (Devarim 8:18) stresses that Hakadosh Baruch Hu provides the actual physical stamina to execute our plans. Furthermore, why does the Torah place the fundamental mitzvah of Birkas Hamazon—"V'achalta v'savata u'verachta es Hashem Elokecha" (Devarim 8:10)—directly within this parshah? The Sefer Hachinuch (Mitzvah 430) explains that when a person feels satiated and comfortable, his natural inclination is to forget his dependence on shamayim. Similarly, the Sforno (Devarim 8:10) notes that reciting a heartfelt berachah after eating specifically neutralizes the arrogance of kochi v'otzem yadi. We are merely guests holding empty plates; our clever strategies and hard work are nothing more than ballroom navigation, while every morsel of parnasah is pure chesed from Hakadosh Baruch Hu.

Practical Takeaway: How do we translate this profound nimshal into our daily avodah during the upcoming week? Every time we step away from a successful workday, or even when we conquer the Sunday morning rush at the local bakery without getting elbowed near the rogelach, we must consciously reject the kochi v'otzem yadi mentality. The Chovos Halevavos (Shaar Habitachon, Perek 3) warns that whenever a person places his trust in his own intelligence or professional schemes, Hakadosh Baruch Hu leaves him to rely solely on those frail human mechanisms. Conversely, one who attributes his achievements to shamayim is granted true menuchas hanefesh. Therefore, our practical takeaway is to transform our daily berachos—especially Birkas Hamazon and the berachah acharonah we mumble after our morning coffee in the kolel—into moments of deliberate hakaras hatov. The Mishnah Berurah (185:1) reminds us of the importance of reciting Birkas Hamazon with awe and concentration, while the Chayei Adam (5:1) emphasizes that uttering a berachah with genuine kavanah is the ultimate antidote to haughtiness. Tomorrow, when your business deal closes smoothly or when you successfully navigate the carpool line without a fender bender, do not pat yourself on the back for your superior driving reflexes or financial genius. Instead, open a sidur, pronounce the words of Birkas Hamazon from inside the text, and openly acknowledge the true Baal Simchah. By remembering Who filled our plates, we ensure that our gashmiyus never breeds arrogance, but instead fuels a lifetime of authentic yiras shamayim and joyful avodas Hashem.

GOOD SHABBUS!